

Opening pawn grabs need an exit plan

Opening Decisions

THE IDEA

Taking a pawn can cost development or trap the capturing piece. Before grabbing, calculate the opponent's forcing replies and identify a safe route home. Material gains are strongest when they do not hand over an enduring initiative.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A queen that takes b2 may win a pawn but face rook moves, bishop attacks, and blocked retreat squares. The capture is sometimes theoretical and sound; the point is to calculate the cage, not label every b-pawn poisoned.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What makes an opening pawn 'poisoned'?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Accepting it allows compensation stronger than the material gain, such as a trapped queen, lost development, or an attack on the king. Demonstrate the concrete continuation before using the label.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Win pawns you can keep without losing the initiative for free.